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Department of Anthropology

**Gender Roles and Cultural Change among the Mon Community in Wang Ka,
Sangkhlaburi, Thailand**

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Abstract

This study examines gender roles and cultural change within the Mon community of Wang Ka Village. It explores how gender expectations are shaped by cultural traditions, religious practices, and identity preservation in a minority community located along the Thai–Myanmar border. The research is based on qualitative secondary data from Chaichana, Jai-aree, and Tanpichai (2018) and Worawong and Jaruworn (2022), supplemented by two informal interviews with local residents to provide contemporary insights.

Using a cultural anthropological perspective, the study analyzes how traditional gender roles are structured through ritual participation, kinship responsibilities, and symbolic cultural systems. At the same time, it examines how these roles are being reshaped by modernization, education, and tourism. The findings indicate that ritual traditions continue to reinforce gendered divisions of labor, particularly in religious leadership and community organization, where men typically occupy authoritative roles while women contribute through supportive and organizational tasks.

However, economic transformation—especially through tourism around the Mon Bridge—and increased access to education have expanded women’s participation in economic and public life. Interview responses suggest that these changes are perceived not as a rejection of tradition but as a natural and necessary adaptation. This study concludes that gender roles in the Mon community are evolving gradually while remaining embedded within enduring cultural frameworks. It contributes to anthropological discussions on gender, identity, and cultural change in minority communities.

I. Introduction

1.1 Research Topic and Contextualization

This research examines gender roles and cultural change among the Mon community in Wang Ka Village. Gender roles refer to socially constructed expectations and responsibilities assigned to men and women within a cultural system, while cultural change refers to transformations in practices, values, and identities over time.

The Mon are one of the oldest ethnic groups in Southeast Asia, originally from Myanmar. Many migrated to Thailand due to political conflict, economic hardship, and displacement. A major turning point occurred in the 1980s with the construction of the Vajiralongkorn Dam, which led to the relocation of Mon communities and contributed to the formation of Wang Ka Village as it exists today. Despite these disruptions, the Mon have preserved their cultural identity through language, religion, and traditional practices.

According to Chaichana et al. (2018), Mon identity is actively constructed through cultural education, community institutions, and collective memory. This process of identity construction ensures that cultural traditions are maintained even within a different national context.

Similarly, Worawong and Jaruworn (2022) emphasize that ritual traditions, particularly Buddhist ceremonies and calendrical rites, structure social life and reinforce moral values.

Gender roles are closely embedded within these cultural systems. Religious practices, family structures, and community expectations define appropriate roles for men and women. From a cultural anthropological perspective, gender is not biologically determined but socially constructed through cultural practices and symbolic meanings. Therefore, understanding gender

roles in the Mon community requires examining how they are shaped by both tradition and contemporary change.

1.2 Scope of the Study

This study focuses specifically on gender roles and cultural change within the Mon community in Wang Ka Village. It examines how traditional roles are maintained and how they are adapting in response to modernization, tourism, and education.

The research is limited to two main concepts: gender roles and cultural change. It does not aim to represent all Mon communities but provides an in-depth analysis of one specific context. The study relies on secondary qualitative data from two key academic sources and is supplemented by two informal interviews with local residents. These interviews provide additional perspectives on everyday practices and lived experiences.

1.3 Research Framework

1.3.1 Cultural Systems

Cultural systems include rituals, religious practices, traditions, and social norms that organize community life. These systems define moral expectations and shape behavior.

1.3.2 Gender Roles

Gender roles refer to the socially assigned responsibilities and expectations for men and women. These roles are expressed through ritual participation, family duties, and economic activities.

1.3.3 Cultural Change

Cultural change occurs when communities adapt to new conditions such as tourism, education, and cross-cultural interaction. This study examines how these changes influence gender roles.

II. Literature Review

Anthropological research emphasizes that gender roles are culturally constructed and embedded within systems of meaning such as kinship, religion, and identity. In ethnic minority communities, gender roles often play a key role in cultural preservation.

Chaichana et al. (2018) analyze the construction of Mon ethnic identity in Ban Wangka. Their study highlights that identity is not static but actively reproduced through language, education, and community institutions. This process ensures continuity while allowing adaptation.

Worawong and Jaruworn (2022) focus on calendrical rites and traditions. They demonstrate that rituals structure time, reinforce moral values, and strengthen social cohesion. Participation in rituals creates a shared sense of identity and belonging.

However, both studies give limited attention to gender roles. While they describe participation in rituals, they do not explicitly analyze how gender shapes these roles. This gap is significant because gender is a fundamental aspect of social organization. This study addresses this gap by integrating gender analysis into the study of cultural systems.

III. Methodology

3.1 Research Design

This research uses a qualitative approach based on secondary data analysis. This method is suitable because it allows for reinterpretation of existing ethnographic research to explore new questions about gender roles.

3.2 Data Sources

Data were collected from:

- Ethnographic interviews (Chaichana et al., 2018)
- Observations of rituals (Worawong & Jaruworn, 2022)
- Two informal interviews with residents

3.3 Analytical Method

The study uses thematic analysis to identify patterns related to gender roles, cultural preservation, and change. These themes are interpreted through a cultural anthropological lens.

IV. Findings (Results)

4.1 Ritual Life Reinforces Gendered Responsibilities

Ritual life remains central in the Mon community. Men often take leadership roles in ceremonies, interacting with monks and representing authority. Women play essential roles in preparing offerings and organizing events.

Interview evidence supports this pattern:

“When there is a festival, women prepare food while men lead the ceremony.”

This division reflects traditional gender hierarchy. Although women's roles are essential, they are less visible and less formally recognized. Ritual practices therefore reinforce existing gender structures.

4.2 Women as Cultural Preservers

Women play a crucial role in maintaining cultural identity, particularly within the family. They are responsible for teaching language, traditions, and values to children.

One participant explained:

“My mother told us to speak Mon at home so we don't lose our culture.”

This highlights how cultural transmission occurs through everyday practices. Women's roles in the household are essential for preserving identity, even though they may not hold formal authority in public spaces.

4.3 Cultural Change and Expanding Roles

Modernization, tourism, and education have created new opportunities. Many women now participate in economic activities, especially in tourism-related businesses near the Mon Bridge.

A male participant noted:

“Now many women earn income from tourism.”

Education also plays a significant role. Younger generations, especially women, have greater access to schooling, which changes their aspirations and opportunities. These developments expand women's roles beyond traditional expectations.

V. Discussion

The findings demonstrate that gender roles in Wang Ka Village are deeply embedded within cultural systems. Ritual practices and identity construction reinforce traditional roles, particularly in leadership and domestic responsibilities. However, modernization introduces new opportunities that challenge these roles.

Cultural change occurs through adaptation rather than replacement. The Mon community integrates new economic and social practices while maintaining cultural identity. This process reflects what anthropologists describe as “adaptive continuity,” where traditions persist but evolve over time.

Cross-cultural interaction with Thai society and tourism further influences gender roles. Exposure to new ideas about gender equality encourages more flexible roles. However, traditional values remain influential, particularly in ritual contexts.

VI. Conclusion

This study shows that gender roles in the Mon community are shaped by cultural traditions but are gradually transforming due to modernization. Ritual systems and identity practices continue to reinforce traditional expectations, while education and economic change expand opportunities, especially for women.

The Mon community demonstrates that cultural identity can be preserved while adapting to change. Gender roles evolve within cultural frameworks, reflecting the dynamic nature of

culture. This case highlights the importance of understanding gender as part of broader cultural systems.

References

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